

EG US Daily: Watch for moves against Federal Election Commission

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US Daily

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Watch for moves against Federal Election Commission. President Trump's dismissal of all commissioners on the Election Assistance Commission (EAC) is mostly a nothingburger—but could be a worrying sign for election integrity if it presages action against partisan balance on the Federal Election Commission (FEC), on the grounds that the Supreme Court's ruling last month allows its commissioners to be fired at will.

* The EAC, composed of two commissioners of each party along with a professional staff, is a federal advisory body tasked with helping states administer elections. But it has been hamstrung by lack of a quorum and a miniscule budget—only \$30 million—for most of its history, meaning that its ultimate impact on election administration is relatively small.

* Without any commissioners, the EAC now will be effectively paralyzed. That works both ways; it will be unable to certify new voting systems, but it will also be unable to implement the White House's proof-of-citizenship requirements to the federal voter-registration form (which had already been blocked by courts).

* Any moves against partisan balance at the FEC, which regulates federal campaign finance law, would be a much bigger deal. The FEC currently has two Democratic commissioners, with two Republican nominations pending; with six slots total, the agency requires a four-commissioner quorum to operate. If Trump moved to appoint four Republicans to the board, it would turn the FEC into a partisan agency that could selectively enforce campaign finance law against Democrats and rewrite regulations to benefit Republicans; that would structurally tilt the electoral playing field away from Democrats ahead of the 2028 presidential election.

Polling update: NATO, Maine, and Trump's key numbers.

* A poll commissioned by NATO found only 43% of American respondents believed NATO would support the US if it was attacked, the lowest score of any NATO country; the alliance-wide average was 57%. This reflects the growing, mutual skepticism between the US and its NATO allies caused by Trump's approach to the alliance, a feeling that will outlive his presidency and complicate rebuilding ties. Polls consistently show stark partisan differences in NATO approval—with one Pew released this week finding 72% of Democrats support the alliance, compared to 42% of Republicans—a trend that is unlikely to subside anytime soon.

* Polling in Maine will help decide Platner's replacement. With Graham Platner, Democrats' Maine Senate nominee, expected to drop out formally by Monday's deadline, Maine Democrats have shifted focus to holding an abbreviated party convention to nominate a new candidate by 27 July. Which candidate has the best chance of defeating Senator Susan Collins (R-ME) will be perhaps the key factor in that decision. A Politico poll found that former Maine Senate president (and progressive favorite) Troy Jackson would beat Collins by five points, with two other serious contenders holding only two-point leads. That polling is good news for Democrats, as it suggests that replacing Platner—who was down by five in the same poll after sexual assault allegations emerged—would substantially increase Democrats' chances in the race.

* The two most important macro-political indicators—Trump's approval rating and the generic congressional ballot—have been largely unchanged over the July 4 period. Trump's approval, per Silver Bulletin, is hovering between 39 and 40, while Democrats maintain a lead between 6 and 6.5 points in the generic congressional ballot. Both are stronger than Republicans were in late May, but they're still both in firmly negative territory.

Warsh's working groups trend toward the mainstream. The Federal Reserve yesterday released the rosters of the five task forces created by Fed chair Kevin Warsh; the names tend toward the orthodox and reputable, with a number of high-profile academics and central-bank practitioners, as well as a few voices from the corporate world.

* Looking holistically, the task forces are likely to take time to gather evidence, then engage the Federal Open Markets Committee on changes that should be made to the Fed's policy framework and communications.

* The task force on productivity—featuring venture-capitalist Marc Andreessen, growth economist (and recent Anthropic hire) Charles Jones, and XBOX CEO Asha Sharma—is perhaps the most predisposed towards holding a strong view, in this case toward seeing AI as a major productivity enhancer, without any AI-skeptic voices like MIT economist Daron Acemoglu, whose name had previously been floated.

* The balance-sheet policy review will be the most immediately consequential for the market, but the roster does not provide real hints into what the outcome of the review will be. That the support work will come from Fed staff suggests Warsh will have a significant influence.

Quote of the Day

"It's always better to be the man in the arena. When you make as many endorsements and you're in the fight and you're not in the ivory tower, you're going to get some calls wrong." - Rep. Ro Khanna (D-CA) speaking about his recently-rescinded endorsement of Graham Platner; Khanna, a Yale Law School graduate, has a significant anti-establishment following built largely on his advocacy over the

Epstein files and is making overt moves toward the progressive lane in the 2028 Democratic presidential primary.

On the Radar

13 July: Congress returns from July 4 recess

13 July: Deadline for Graham Platner to withdraw from Maine Senate race if Democratic Party wishes to name replacement

14 July: Fed chair Kevin Warsh testifies before the House Financial Services Committee.

15 July: Senate Judiciary Committee confirmation hearing for Attorney General nominee Todd Blanche

15 July: Senate Select Committee on Intelligence confirmation hearing for Director of National Intelligence nominee Jay Clayton

16 July: Senate Committee on Health, Education, Labor and Pensions holds confirmation hearing for Secretary of Labor nominee Keith Sonderling.

24 July: Section 122 tariffs expire

27 July: Deadline for Maine Democratic Party to name Senate candidate if Platner drops out

4 August: Michigan primary election

3 November: National midterm elections

EG United States

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Kendal Walker

Senior Analyst, United States

walker@eurasiagroup.net

Jason Walter

Researcher, United States

walter@eurasiagroup.net

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